

All day she thought about her options and silently prayed. As far as she was concerned, her marriage was over—and she didn't know what she was going to do. She had purposely opened her own checking account so that she could accumulate some funds if, and when, she went out on her own. But she knew she didn't make enough money to pay for childcare, a place to live, a car, and other expenses. She was shocked by her own thoughts. Had she actually been planning to leave Ben? Then she realized that it was not a divorce she wanted. She wanted to be free of the pressures they had been facing since the day they got married. Ben was a good man, and she believed he loved her. It was just that he was so irresponsible about money.

That evening Naomi found Ben already home and preparing supper in the kitchen. "Ben," she said in genuine astonishment, "why are you home so early? Is anything wrong at work?"

"No," Ben said without looking up. "I just realized that because of my stupidity I have lost something very precious to me." He pulled her to himself and hugged her, as Timmy played happily on the floor. "It's not more money I need. I need help. I called Pastor Rhimer today and explained what a mess I've made of our finances and our marriage. The pastor is willing to work with me on the marriage, but he recommended a financial coach in the church to help with our finances. So I called him."

"Ben, I think that's great," Naomi said with enthusiasm.

"But the financial coach won't meet unless we both go. I didn't know what to tell him," Ben said.

Naomi knew what he wanted her to say.

"Call and tell him we'll be glad to meet," Naomi said as she rested in his arms. "I just pray there is a way out of the mess we're in."

Ben and Naomi met with the coach, Bryan Stanford, the following week. Bryan asked them each to complete a short personality test before the session actually began. A few minutes later he called them into his office.